Climate psychology: From value-action gap to ecological co-development

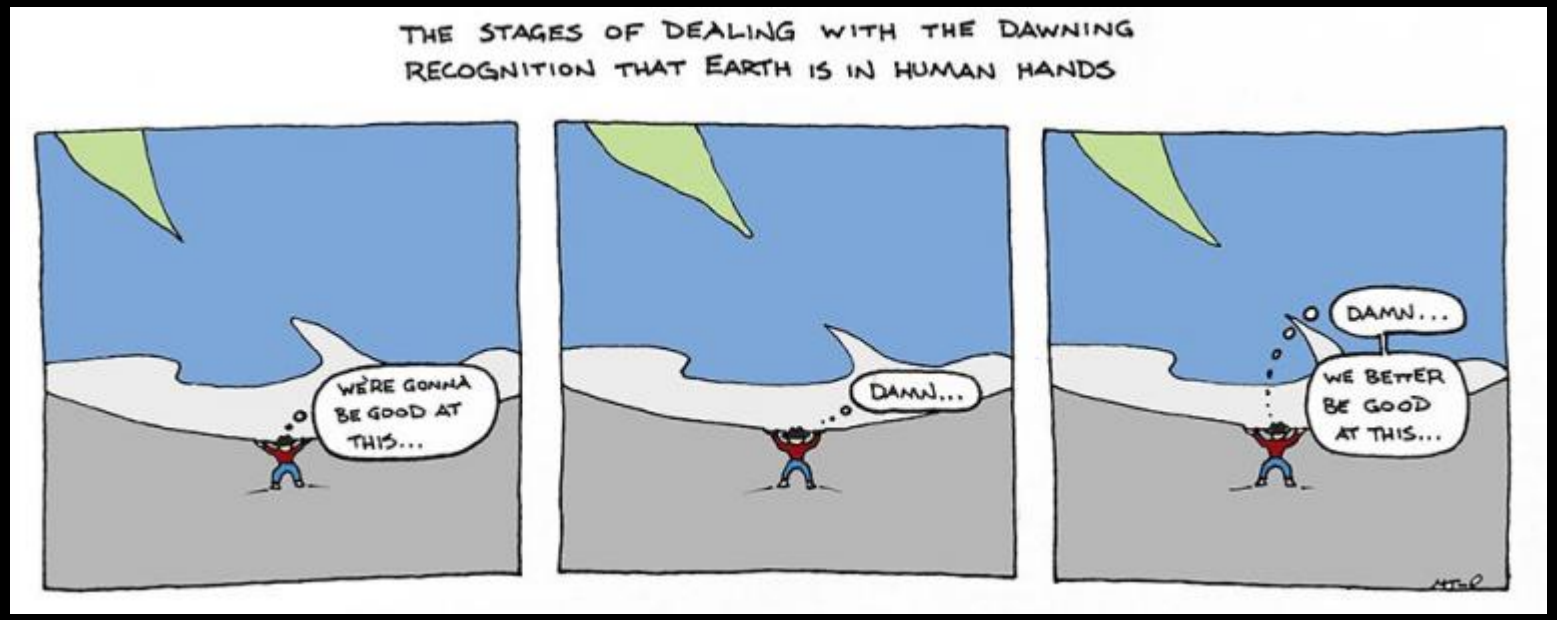
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Living in the Anthropocene I Elective Course I E2026 I October 12, 2026



extreme (historical) inequality + existential doubt
= cynical phlegma?
(or perhaps worse: eco-trauma and eco-anxiety; e.g., Rhodes, 2021)







Climate psychology:
from individual choice to mutual care

1. Climate psychology's hitherto focus on the value-action gap and its inbuilt limitations

2. Toward a pedagogically inspired, co-developmental ecopsychology of care

Let’s talk about your values first

- Who of you consciously chose the ecologically produced sandwich cookies over the others?
- Who believes it does not make a real difference which kind of products we buy in the supermarket?
- Discuss with each other what makes it difficult to choose the ‘best’ product, given your values?



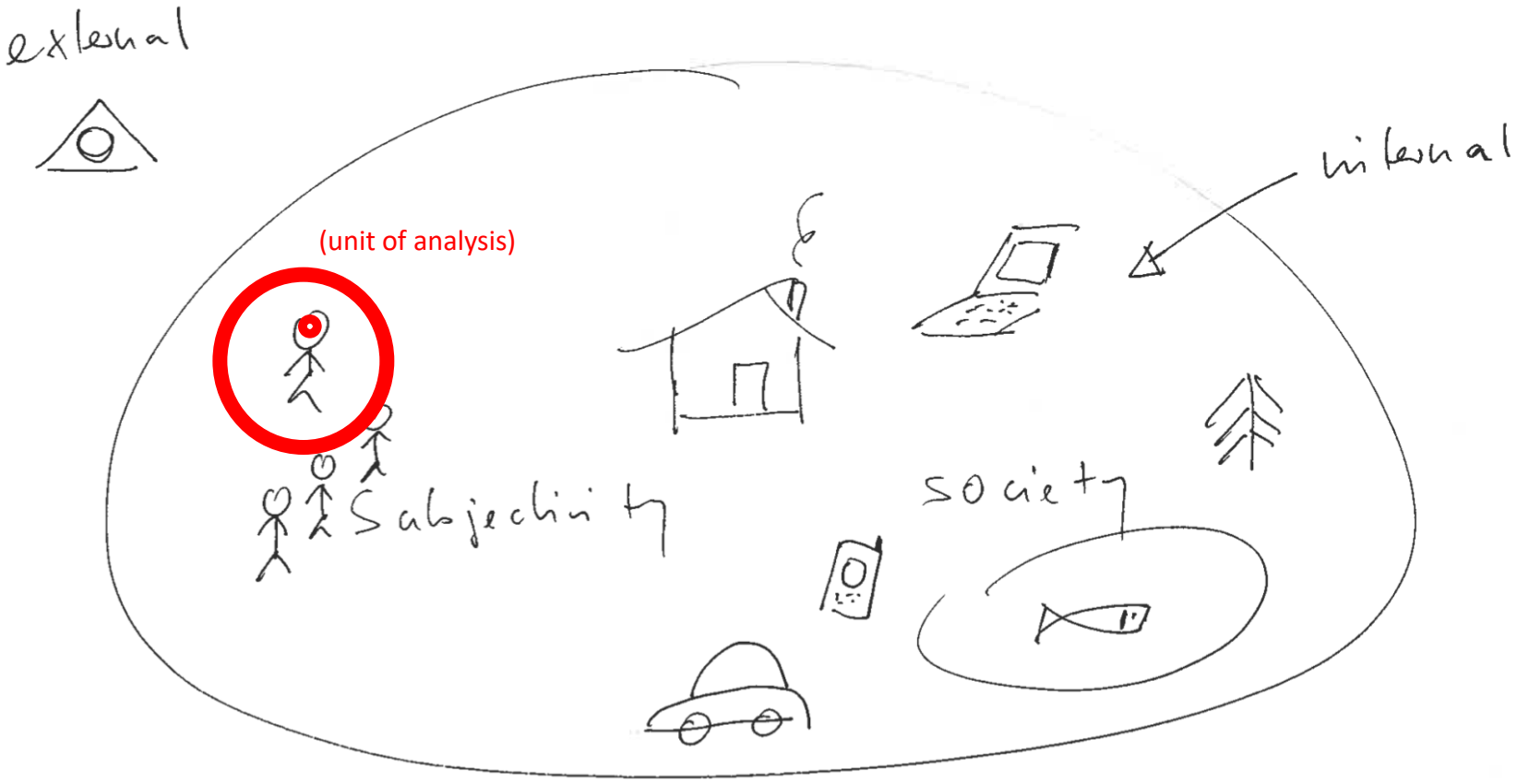
Why is not everyone
choosing the ‘best’ option?

Behavioral-cognitivist climate psychology: pro-environmental action as individual consumer choice

The answer as to why there is such a great divide in opinions between scientists and the public (and between sections of the public) … [is to be considered] in psychological terms. … [It] involves *individuals* and their beliefs, values, attitudes and behaviour, which, we would argue, can be thought of as sitting at the centre of everything, with their values and attitudes driving consumer behaviour and the production of goods.

Beattie & McGuire (2019, pp. 4-5)

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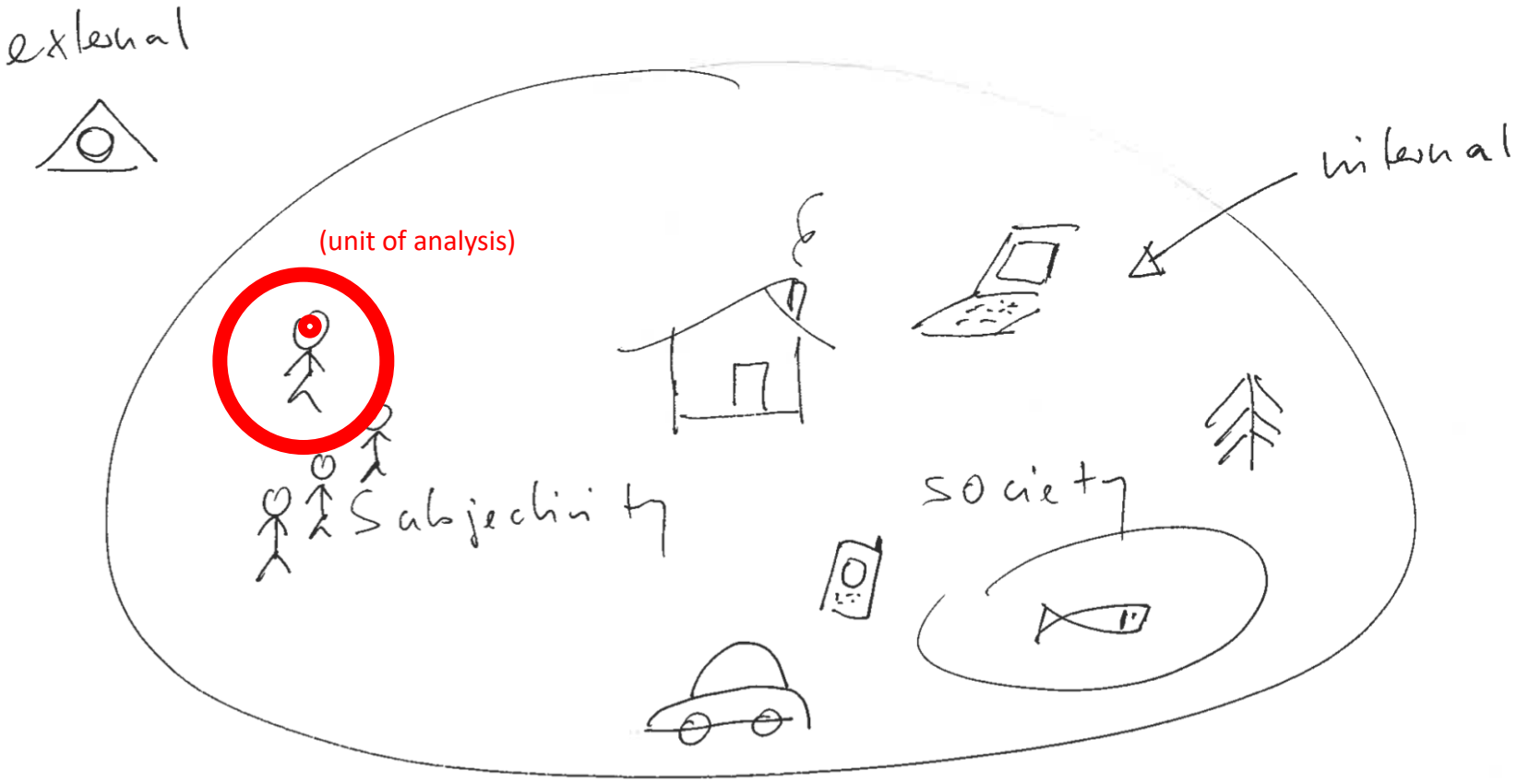
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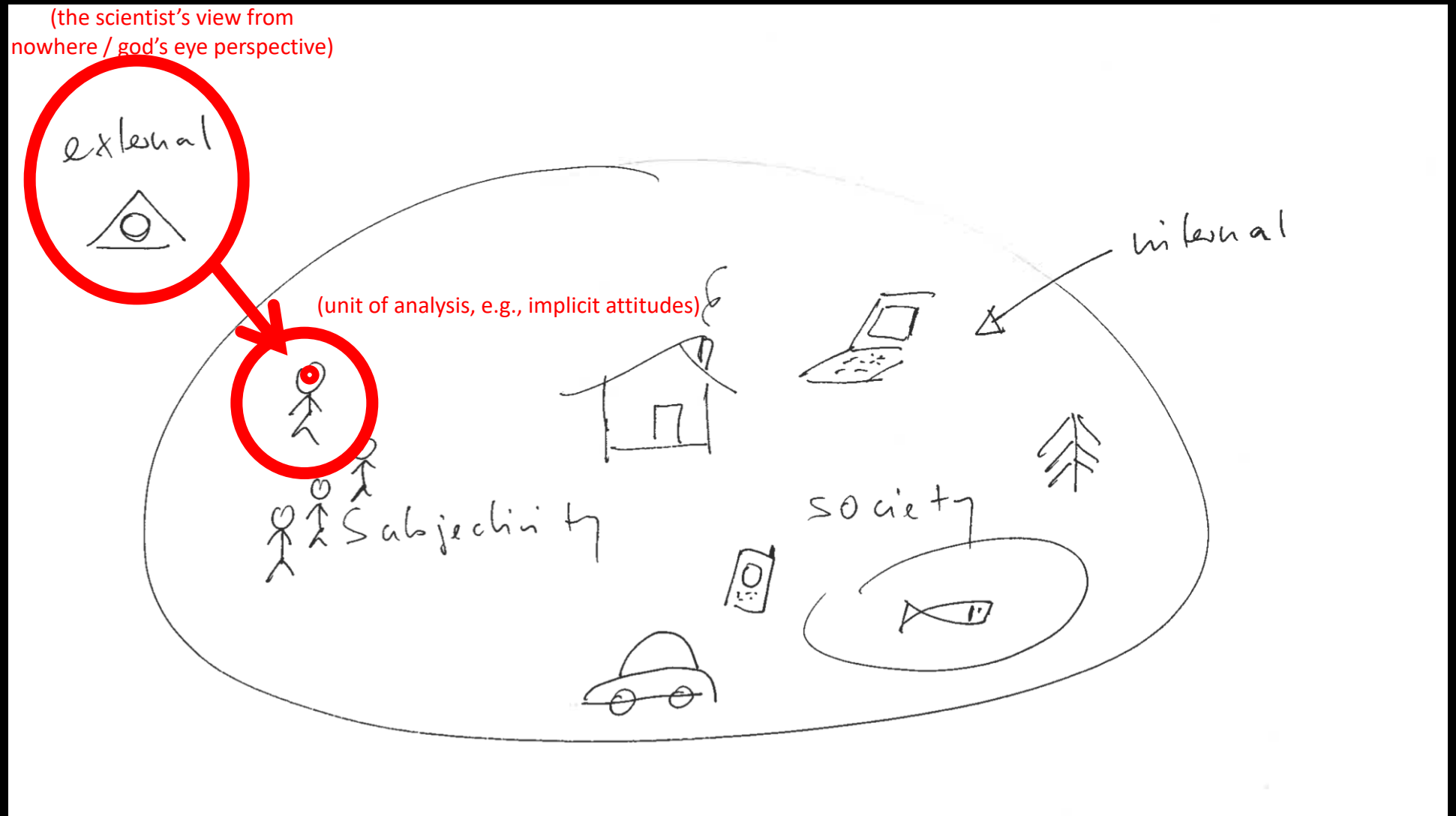
Why is not everyone choosing the ‘best’ option?

Why isn’t everyone just following the experts’ advice?

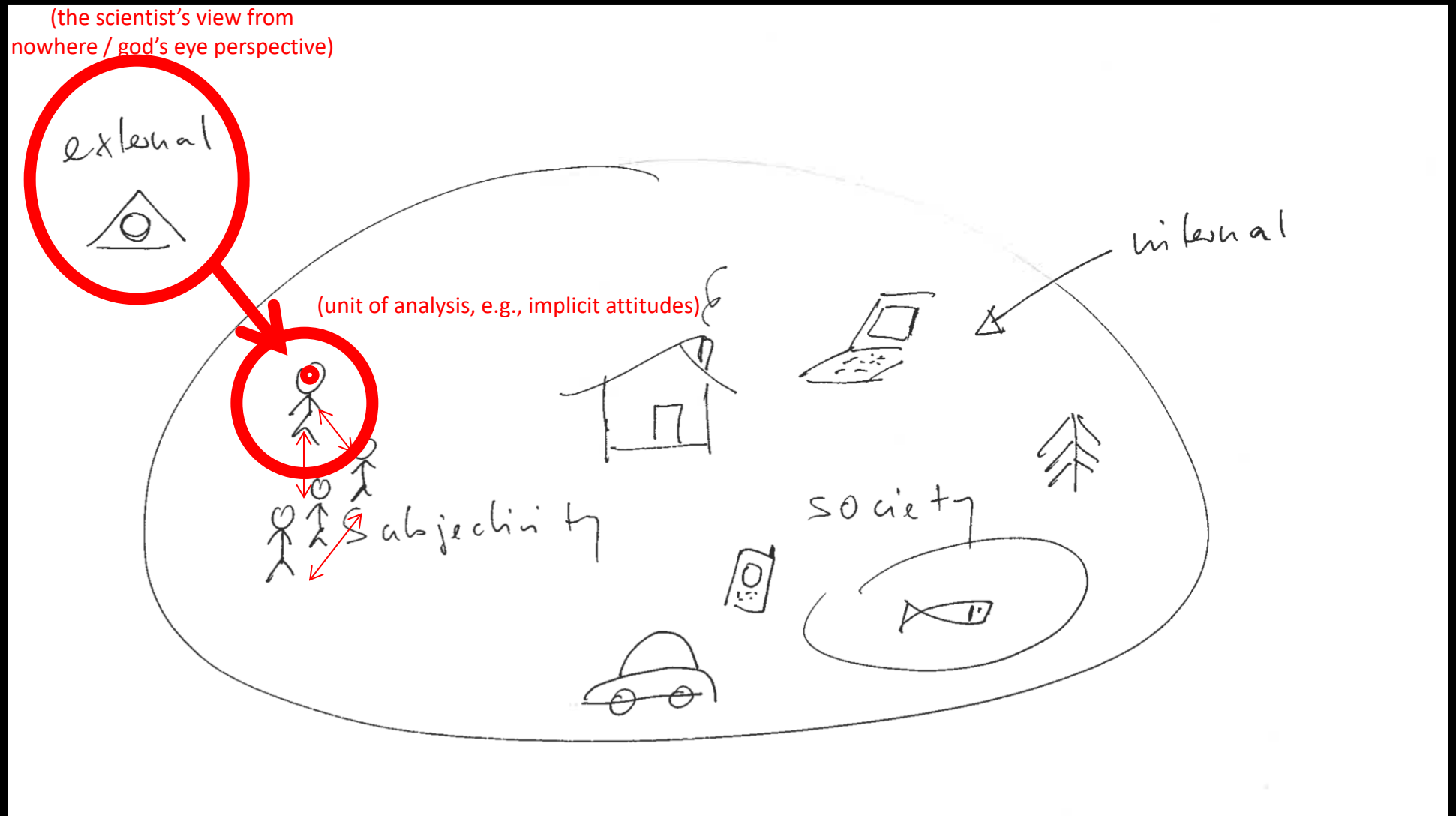
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Behavioral-cognitivist climate psychology: pro-environmental action as individual consumer choice



Behavioral-cognitivist climate psychology: pro-environmental action as individual consumer choice => OTHERS appear here as independent variables & social bias



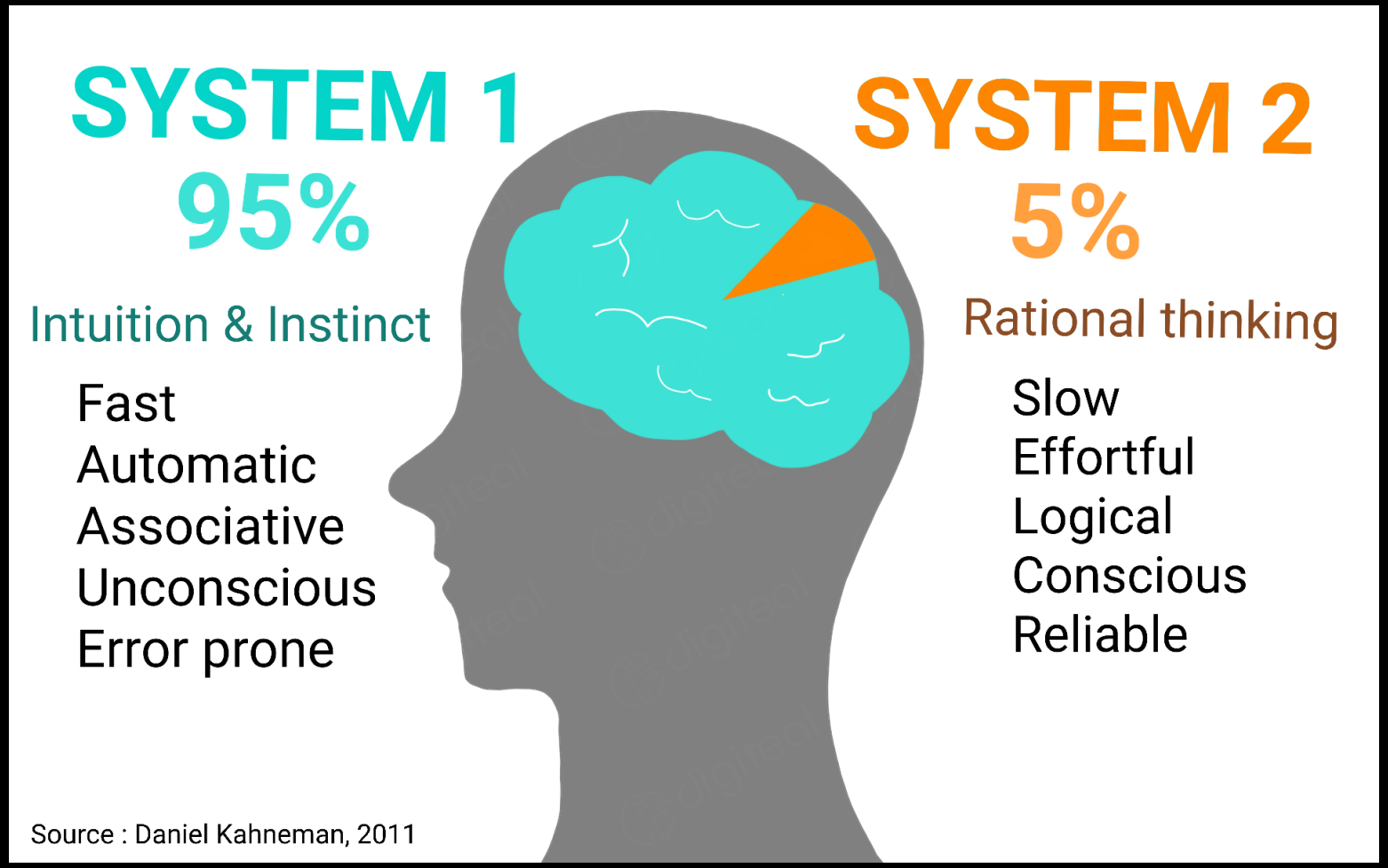
Behavioral-cognitivist climate psychology: pro-environmental action as individual consumer choice => OTHERS appear here as independent variables & social bias

[W]hen people were aware that their choices could be observed by others and had the possibility of influencing other peoples' perception of them, they were more likely to choose pro-environmental products. […] [In a different study,] participants were significantly more likely to choose low carbon items when shopping alone than when shopping with friends […].

We concluded that it will not be enough just to transmit the basic information about carbon footprint; rather, we need to change our underlying emotions and values about it. […] In the terminology of Kahneman, we need to appeal to System 1 and allow our immediate, automatic and emotional response to guide our consumer choices. We need more of an instant response.

Beattie & McGuire (2019, pp. 80-81)

=> Their 'solution': behaviorally-cognitively changing IMPLICIT attitudes



https://www.davidadcock.de/presentation/communicating_across_cultures/006.png

=> Their ‘solution’: behaviorally-cognitively changing IMPLICIT attitudes

The value-action gap, aka attitude-behavior gap, or: Why do we not act (more) according to the experts' advice?

- According to Gifford (2011) and other climate psychologists, a vast number of psychological barriers (Gifford: "Dragons of Inaction") keep us from acting on our environmental concerns and the underlying values

- The "Dragons of Inaction" manifest themselves when pro-environmental behavior is <u>not structurally impeded</u>

- A widespread evolutionary explanation: Our ancient brains cannot process the necessary amount of information on a daily basis…

Table 1
Psychological Barriers to Climate Change Mitigation and Adaptation

General psychological barrier	Specific manifestation
Limited cognition	Ancient brain Ignorance Environmental numbness Uncertainty Judgmental discounting Optimism bias Perceived behavioral control/ self-efficacy
Ideologies	Worldviews Suprahuman powers Technosalvation System justification
Comparisons with others	Social comparison Social norms and networks Perceived inequity
Sunk costs	Financial investments Behavioral momentum Conflicting values, goals, and aspirations
Discredence	Mistrust Perceived program inadequacy Denial Reactance
Perceived risks	Functional Physical Financial Social Psychological Temporal
Limited behavior	Tokenism Rebound effect

Nudging as example for ‘expert design’ appealing to System 1, building on a social theory that Thaler & Sunstein call *libertarian paternalism*:

To borrow a phrase from the late Milton Friedman, libertarian paternalists urge that people should be ‘free to choose.’ We strive to design policies that maintain or increase freedom of choice. When we use the term *libertarian* to modify the word *paternalism,* we simply mean liberty-preserving. And when we say liberty-preserving, we really mean it. Libertarian paternalists want to make it easy for people to go their own way; they do not want to burden those who want to exercise their freedom.

The paternalistic aspect lies in the claim that it is legitimate for choice architects to try to influence people’s behavior in order to make their lives longer, healthier, and better. In other words, we argue for self-conscious efforts, by institutions in the private sector and also by government, to steer people’s choices in directions that will improve their lives. In our understanding, a policy is ‘paternalistic’ if it tries to influence choices in a way that will make choosers better off, *as judged by themselves*.

Thaler & Sunstein (2008, s. 5)

- Read the quote and shortly discuss with your neighbors: What vision of sociality and/or society is offered here, what vision of politics and science?

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> "Loneliness kills. It's as powerful as smoking or alcoholism."
>
> — Robert Waldinger, psychiatrist, Massachusetts General Hospital

startling lessons, and not only for the researchers.

"The surprising finding is that our relationships and how happy we are in our relationships has a powerful influence on our health," said **Robert Waldinger**, director of the study, a psychiatrist at **Massachusetts General Hospital** and a professor of psychiatry at **Harvard Medical School**. "Taking care of your body is important, but tending to your relationships is a form of self-care too. That, I think, is the revelation."

Close relationships, more than money or fame, are what keep people happy throughout their lives, the study revealed. Those ties protect people from life's discontents, help to delay mental and physical decline, and are better predictors of long and happy lives than social class, IQ, or even genes. That finding proved true across the board among both the Harvard men and the inner-city participants.

OTHERS primarily as 'social bias'…?

- Human beings as ultra-social animals (Tomasello)
- Early attachment as crucial to well-being (Bowlby, Honneth)
- Human beings as inherently societal and world-making (Marx, Vygotsky, Lewin, Holzkamp)
- Nakkerud (2021): living childfree as a couple's decision

https://news.harvard.edu/gazette/story/2017/04/over-nearly-80-years-harvard-study-has-been-showing-how-to-live-a-healthy-and-happy-life/

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<u>Discuss</u>: When is pro-environmental behavior not structurally impeded?

Human beings as fossile subjects?



"A typical Western person enjoys the services of tens of energy slaves as if by birth right, while absolute poverty is as grim as before. As [Simone] Weil begun to observe, floating on the work of energy slaves and the work of human laborers, a typical Western person imagines him/herself as a master of his/her life, forgetting its material conditions of existence" (Vadén & Salminen, 2018, s. 40)

A house.
A car. Lights at night and heat in the winter.
A refrigerator to keep food fresh and a stove for cooking.
A better education and a good job. Modern health care.
Wireless communications. Technology and innovation.
The freedom to focus one's daily activities on something more than mere subsistence. These are among the many benefits of modern energy. . . . So why energy? Because energy is **vital** in our everyday lives.
ExxonMobil, "The Outlook for Energy: A View to 2040" (2015)

“When we flush the toilet, we imagine the the U-bend takes the waste away into some ontologically alien realm” (Morton, 2013, s. 115).





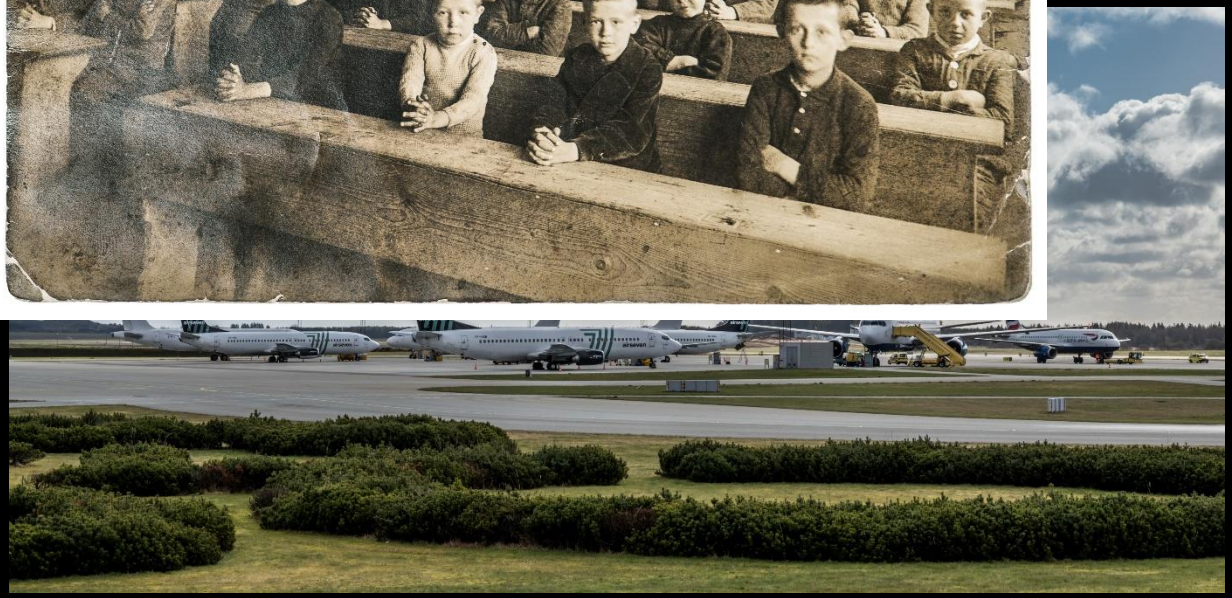












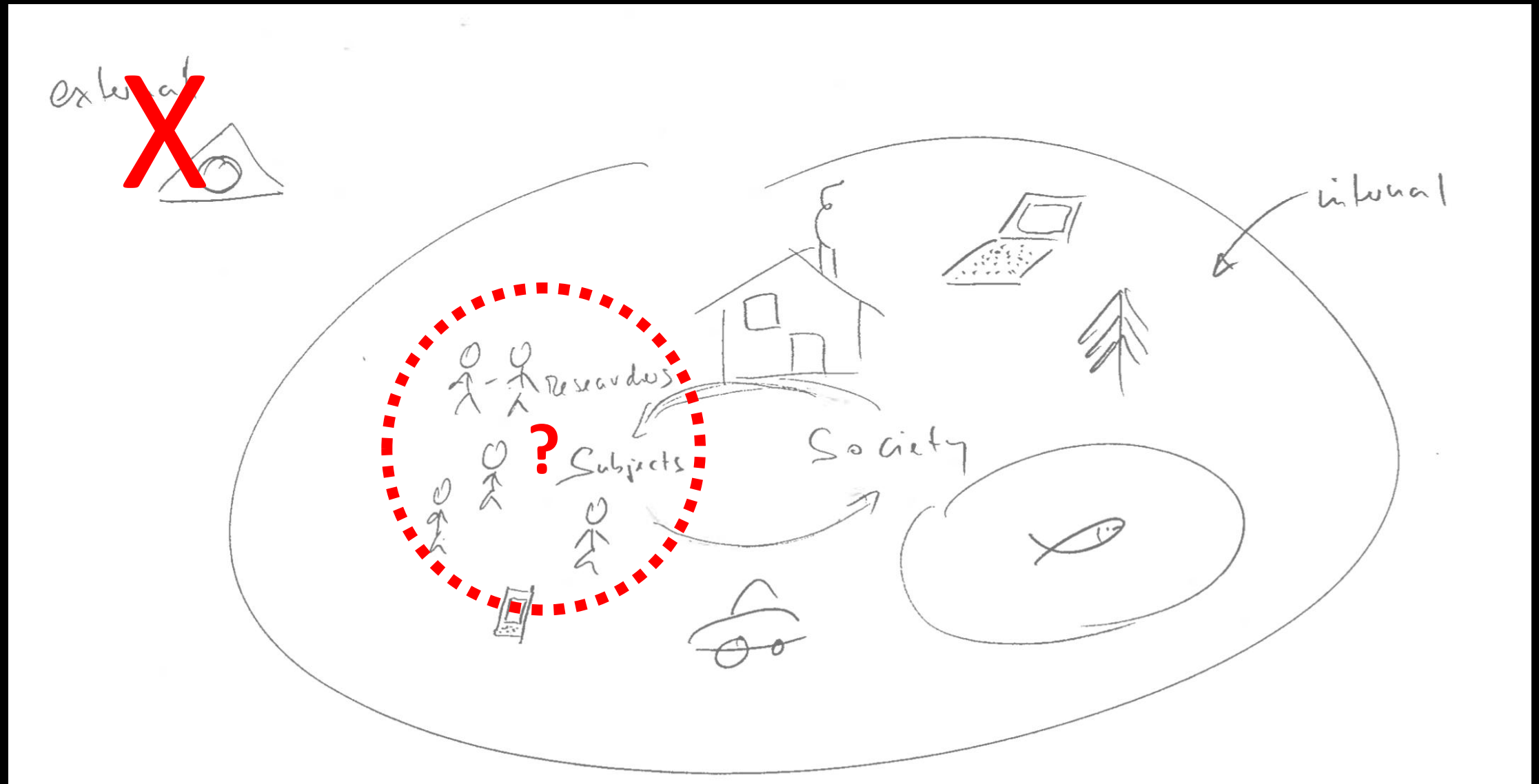
Departing from pedagogy and/or education

The Common Worlds Research Collective & its call for *Learning to Become with the World*

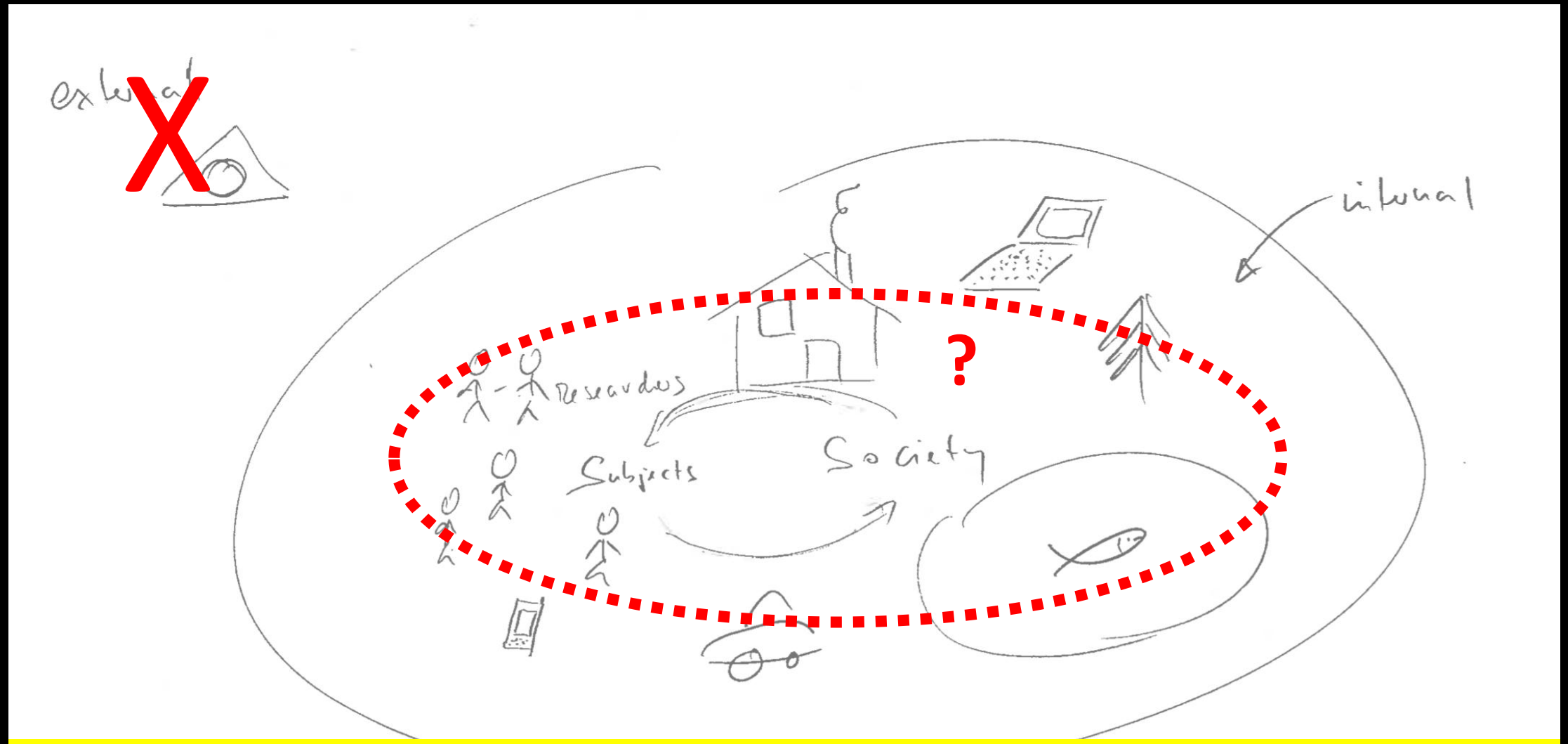
7 declarations for future survival education (Common Worlds Research Collective, 2020)

1. By 2050, we have critically reassessed and reconfigured the relationship between education and humanism. We now retain the best aspect of education's previous humanist mission – to promote justice – but extend it beyond an exclusively human or social framework.
2. By 2050, we have fully acknowledged that humans are embedded within ecosystems and that we are ecological, not just social, beings. We have dissolved the boundaries between the 'natural' and 'social' sciences, and all curricula and pedagogies are now firmly grounded in an ecological consciousness.
3. By 2050, we have stopped using education as a vehicle for promulgating human exceptionalism. We are teaching that agency is relational, collectively distributed, and more-than-human.
4. By 2050, we have discarded education's human development/al frameworks. Instead of championing individualism, we now foster collective dispositions and convivial, reparative human and more-than-human relations.
5. **BY 2050, WE HAVE RECOGNIZED THAT WE LIVE AND LEARN IN A WORLD. OUR PEDAGOGIES NO LONGER POSITION THE WORLD 'OUT-THERE' AS THE OBJECT WE ARE LEARNING ABOUT. LEARNING TO BECOME WITH THE WORLD IS A SITUATED PRACTICE AND A MORE-THAN-HUMAN PEDAGOGICAL COLLABORATION.**
6. By 2050, we have re-tasked education with a cosmopolitical remit. This has moved it far beyond the universalist and anthropocentric claims of humanist, humanitarian, and human rights perspectives.
7. By 2050, the goal of education for future survival has led us to prioritise an ethics of collective recuperation on this damaged Earth.

An epistemological shift: From a “God’s eye view” and its external, disconnected scientific standpoint TOWARD co-development of ecologically more meaningful questions and explorative collective actions from within everyday life



An epistemological shift: From a “God’s eye view” and its external, disconnected scientific standpoint TOWARD co-development of ecologically more meaningful questions and explorative collective actions from within everyday life



Implies a different view on the individual, the social, the societal – including politics and science

Why do ~~people~~ act in contradictory ways in everyday life?

we

(systematically include the researcher's body and emotions in psychology's problematizations…)



And where may there be meaning-full understandings and actions in what they-we are already doing?







What are YOU already doing in order to live a more meaning-full life…?

Joan Tronto's *caring democracy:*

From care's metabolic rift to organizing mutual care together

The neoliberal ways of organizing care *(homo oeconomicus)*	**A more democratic way of understanding and organizing care** *(homines curans)*
1. Care as personal responsibility, as ego-project ('commitments that set us free')	1. *Caring about – attentiveness*: someone or some group notices unmet caring needs
	2. *Caring for – responsibility*: once identified, someone takes responsibility to make sure that needs are met
2. Care as a market problem, that in turn (only) the market can solve/rectify	3. *Caregiving – competence (capability?)*: the actual caregiving work is done by trying to meet the needs
	4. ***Care-receiving*** *– responsiveness*: what's the response? (When) is there any? Has the need really been met?
3. The family as the proper (and only?) true locus of care	5. ***Caring with***: occurs if a reliable cycle of care is established; produces trust & solidarity
Tronto (2017): "within a neoliberal society: care for yourself by acting rationally and responsibly; if there are care needs that you cannot meet for yourself, then use market solutions; and, finally, if you cannot afford market solutions, or prefer to care on your own, then enlist family (and perhaps friends and charities) to meet your caring needs" (s. 30)	Tronto (2017): assignment of responsibility as a collective act; **all humans** as **fragile & vulnerable, as care givers & recipients**; care as contextual & non-essentialist; care as political ideal Tronto (2015): "**Democracy** is the allocation of caring responsibilities and assuring that everyone can participate in those allocations of care as completely as possible" (s. 15)

A few (highly tentative) conceptual propositions:

What does a forest patch (pedagogically-psychologically) invite us into?

Development's manifold timescales & em-body-placements: spacious slowness
(fx Slow Pedagogy of Place: Payne & Wattchow, 2009; thinking-with Slow Science: Stengers, 2005)



Demands a different ethics, deeply embodied, which is responsive to both the social and the material environments' invitations: ethical sensitivity
(thanks to Ditte Winther-Lindqvist, 2021 & Barna Kovács, 2022, for inspiration)



Invites us to understand care not as unidirectional need fulfilment, but as a (metabolic?) cycle, i.e. as careful and reciprocal attempts at developing each other's conditions for better taking care of our intradependent livelihood and we being: **mutual care!**



across adults & children,
(and across human & nonhuman forces!?!)



Thank you for your caring!

(and thanks to CeDif, fellow colleagues Jo Krøjer & Thomas Gitz-Johansen for caring-with discussions, to Marie Bille for dissemination, to all project participants and particularly Mette Vinter-Hansen & Sanne Thyrgaard)